WALAMORT FREE GUIDE

First steps on tongue *drum*

FREE

Parts, technique, note map and your first two songs.



@Walamort

11-note tongue drum in C

BEFORE YOU START

Welcome

Hi, I'm Walter, Walamort: a musician, producer and music teacher in Medellín. This guide is my gift to help you begin playing the tongue drum, a welcoming, relaxing instrument. You do not need to read music: everything uses numbers.

In this guide you will learn

- The parts of a tongue drum and how to care for it.
- Posture and striking technique, with mallets and fingers.
- The note map and how to read the numbers.
- Four exercises to loosen up your hands.
- Your first two complete songs.

Your tuning

This material is written for an 11-tongue drum in C with engraved numbers: low G in the center, surrounded by low A, C, D, E, F, G, A, high C, high D and high F. There is no B, so the notes combine easily. If your drum has a different number of tongues, follow its engraved numbers; most models use a similar numbering system.

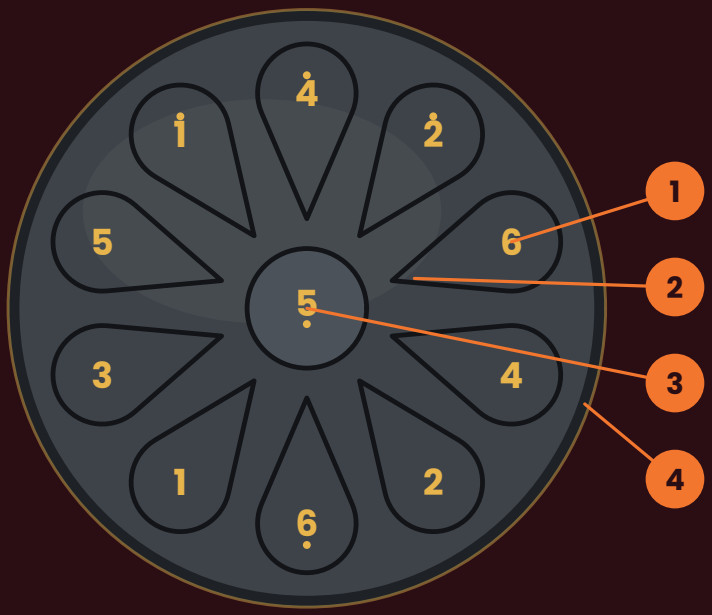
How to use this guide

Read one page a day and practice for ten minutes. In a week, you can be playing your first songs. If you have questions, contact me on WhatsApp or Instagram @Walamort.

MEET THE INSTRUMENT

Parts of your tongue drum

A tongue drum is a steel drum with tongues cut into its top. Each tongue vibrates like a small bell: larger ones sound lower, smaller ones higher. The hollow body acts as a resonating chamber.



1 Tongues

Each one produces a note. Its engraved number tells you which.

2 Cuts

The slots separating each tongue from the body. Never insert anything into them.

3 Center tongue

The lowest note: G. It is your home base and bass note.

4 Body

The hollow drum that resonates. A sound hole sits underneath.

What's in the box

Most tongue drums come with two rubber-tipped mallets, a padded case and sometimes number stickers and a stand. Mallets produce a clear, stronger sound; fingers give a softer, warmer one. You will use both approaches in this material.

Tongue drum or handpan?

They are related instruments. A handpan has shaped tone fields and a long, deep sound. A tongue drum has cut tongues, is smaller and generally more affordable, and can be played with mallets. This makes it a welcoming starting point.

Posture and playing position

Where to place it

On your lap. Sit upright and rest the drum on your thighs, with high F (4 with a dot above) away from you and low A close to you.

On a table or stand. Place a cushion or case underneath, keeping the bottom sound hole clear.

Never directly on tile or glass. This dampens the sound and may scratch the steel.

How to strike

1. **A bouncing strike**
   Strike and lift away immediately, as if the tongue were hot. Leaving the mallet or finger on it stops the note ringing.

2. **Aim near the tip**
   The clearest sound comes near each tongue's rounded tip, rather than beside the cut at its base.

3. **With mallets**
   Hold them loosely between thumb and index finger. Let them rebound naturally, like a ball.

4. **With fingers**
   Use the pad of your index or middle finger with a relaxed wrist. The sound is more intimate, ideal for quiet practice or meditation.

Less force, more resonance

A tongue drum does not need forceful strikes. A light, quick touch sounds clearer and rings longer than a heavy hit.

The note map

The notes use numbers: 1 is C, 2 is D, 3 is E, 4 is F, 5 is G and 6 is A. A dot below a number means the lower register; a dot above means the upper register. The layout zigzags, rising alternately left and right.



FROM LOWEST TO HIGHEST

5	6	1	2	3	4	5	6	1	2	4
G	A	C	D	E	F	G	A	C	D	F

Left hand

The tongues on your left: 1, 3, 5 and 1 **(high).**

Right hand

Those on your right: 2, 4, 6 and high 2. Use whichever hand is free for the center, low A and high F.

WALAMORT NOTATION

How to read the songs

Each box equals one beat: the steady pulse you would tap with your foot. Bar lines group beats into bars, usually four beats each. Read from left to right, as you would a sentence.

3 **Number**
The tongue to play: 3 is E.

5 **Dot below**
The low note: 5 with a dot below is the center G.

1 **Dot above**
The high note: 1 with a dot above is high C.

— **Dash**
Let the previous note ring for one more beat without striking again.

· **Rest**
One beat without playing. Count it just like the others.

| **Bar line**
The end of a bar. Start counting again from one.

How to count

Count aloud as you play: one, two, three, four. Each spoken number is one box.

EXAMPLE



Use a metronome

Download a free metronome app and start at 60 beats per minute. Once you can play a song correctly three times in a row, increase to 70, then 80.

LOOSEN UP YOUR HANDS

Your first exercises

Practice each exercise slowly, first with one hand, then alternating. Aim for equally clear notes.

Exercise 1 · Four even strikes

Four strikes per note, always at the same volume.



Exercise 2 · Staircase

Move up and down through the notes in the middle of the drum.



Exercise 3 · Low notes

Find the two low notes: the center and the one below.



Exercise 4 · Question and answer

An open-ended phrase followed by one that comes home.



Tip

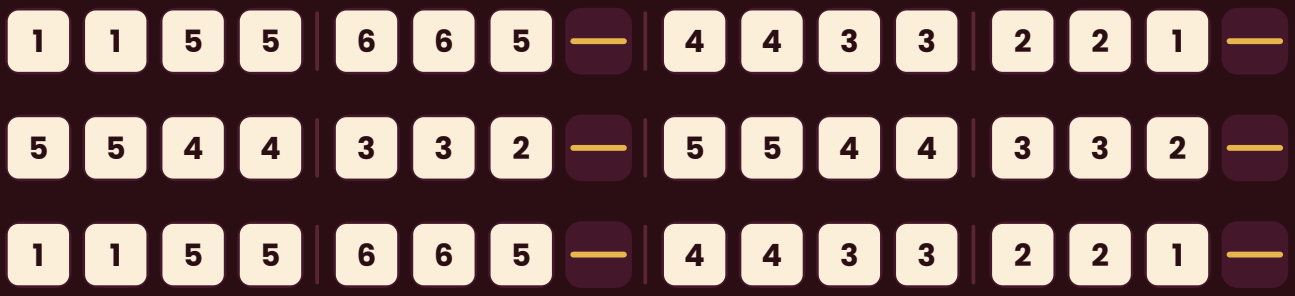
If you cannot find a note, check the map on page 5 before playing. Soon your hands will find it naturally.

Your first two songs

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star

TRADITIONAL

A much-loved lullaby. Notice how 5 and 6 form its highest point.



Ode to Joy

BEETHOVEN · PART A

The theme from the Ninth Symphony. It uses just five neighboring notes: 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5.



Challenge

Record your version of Twinkle, Twinkle and tag @Walamort. I share the videos I receive in my stories!

KEEP IT SOUNDING FOR YEARS

Caring for your tongue drum

A tongue drum is sturdy, but its tuning depends on keeping the tongues unbent and the steel free from rust. These habits will help keep it in good condition.

- Wipe it with a dry microfiber cloth after playing: sweat can leave marks and cause rust.
- If the tongues are unpainted, occasionally apply a very thin layer of protective oil and wipe off the excess.
- Do not leave it in direct sunlight, a hot car or damp places: heat and salt can damage it.
- Store it in its case, with mallets in the pocket, never loose on the tongues.
- Do not strike it with hard or metal objects: use only its mallets or your fingers.

Does a note sound odd?

If a tongue buzzes, check that nothing is touching it underneath and that the cuts are free of dust. If an impact has put it out of tune, do not try to bend it: contact the maker or a specialist.

Before playing

Wash your hands, remove rings and bracelets, and find a quiet place. A tongue drum rewards a calm approach.

WHAT COMES NEXT?

You have taken your first steps.

Keep the music going.

Enjoyed it? Continue with the Walamort tongue drum method: three levels with study plans, over 25 songs and pieces, chords, improvisation and composition. Find it at walamort.com.

Method by level

Beginner COP 24,900 · Intermediate COP 29,900 · Advanced COP 34,900 · Three-level pack COP 69,900.

Online lessons

Personalized video-call lessons, wherever you live. Book at walamort.com.

A new instrument every week

Its history, interesting facts, a beat made with its sounds and the song you choose.

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